famous Jewish banking family of Europe. Interestingly, they were linked to them through a marriage alliance in the late 19th century. The Sassoon family business would grow to own dockyards, oil mills and numerous cotton textile mills and make it a major promoter of the Bank of India that was founded in 1906. Sassoon's global operations led to further migration of Baghdadi Jews, and India soon became a stepping stone for them to receive an English education and protected status before migrating to other places, especially China. For instance, Silas Aaron Hardoon (1851–1931) worked for David Sassoon and Company in India in the late 19th century, before moving to China and amassing a real estate fortune, dying as the richest foreigner in Shanghai.

The Baghdadi Jews distinguished themselves from the Bene Israel Jews of India by claiming to be more 'European, white and loyalist' in a bid to secure protection under the British.[86] After India became independent and the British Empire collapsed, the Baghdadi Jews began to leave for Israel. Today, their numbers in India have dwindled from a few thousand to a few hundred, just like the Scots. With this wave of outmigration, ownership of firms was transferred to Indian hands. Their memory lives on only because of their firm commitment to philanthropy, witnessed for instance at the beautifully restored David Sassoon Library in south Mumbai.

Apart from European Christians and Baghdadi Jews, immigrant traders and entrepreneurs from many other regions have been attracted to India. Among these are the Armenians in Surat, the Burmese and Chinese in Calcutta, and the Iranians in Bombay who, since the late 19th century, have been running inexpensive cafes that enjoy an iconic status now.

The Migration of Capital, c. 1600–2015

If the Great Indian Migration Wave is a narrative of the migration of labour over the past century and a half, the migrations described in this chapter refer to the migration of capital over the past four centuries. They revolved around the family firm, a system whereby sons and nephews first worked as apprentices and then migrated either as agents or entrepreneurs to manage